

Reverse Planning.

*Why most AI startups plan forward from the model – and
how to plan in reverse, starting from the customer.*

Sage Faraday

What's inside.

A short walkthrough — meant to be read in one sitting, and re-read before your next strategy meeting.

01 Forward Planning

Why founders unknowingly plan forward from the technology — and what that actually looks like in a deck.

02 Reverse Planning

The discipline that fixes it. Amazon's PR/FAQ method as one implementation, and the diagnostic line every founder should apply to their own work.

03 How It Shows Up at AI Startups

Three voices — Eric Ries, Sam Altman, Sequoia — saying the same thing in different rooms.

04 Cautionary Tale: Yupp.ai

\$33M, 1.3M users, Chris Dixon as lead — and still no PMF. What forward-from-tech collapse looks like in production.

05 The Diagnostic

Five questions to ask before your next roadmap review. Answer them honestly or don't bother.

01 You're not planning. You're rationalizing.

Most AI founder roadmaps I review have the same secret structure: a list of features the team can build, dressed up as a strategy.

The team starts with what their model can do, what their stack supports, what the latest API release unlocked — and then writes a story backward to make those capabilities sound like customer value. The deck reads like a strategy. The roadmap reads like a plan. But it's not. It's an inventory — the company describing itself.

Forward planning, the kind that starts from what you have rather than where you're going, is the default mode of every technically gifted team I've ever worked with. It feels like progress because the team is shipping. It feels rigorous because there are milestones. But the milestones are about the team, not the customer. And the further down that road you go, the more expensive the U-turn becomes.

"It was working forward from the technology instead of working backward from the business results you're trying to achieve."

ERIC RIES · ON THE FAILURE MODE HE KEPT SEEING

The cure is older than AI, older than the cloud, older than software. It has a name. It has a method. And almost no early-stage AI team is using it.

02 Start with the customer. Then walk it back.

The discipline is called **reverse planning**. You start from the goal and walk the steps backward to today. Amazon's institutional version of it is called **Working Backwards**. Bryar & Carr documented the method; Bezos made it cultural. The artifact is called the PR/FAQ.

Before a single line of production code is written, the team writes the press release that will announce the product on launch day — as if the product already existed and the customer had already bought it. Then they write the FAQ that the press, the customer, and the executive team will inevitably ask. Then, and only then, do they decide whether to build it.

1 THE METHOD, IN ONE SENTENCE

"Start by defining the customer experience, then iteratively work backwards from that point until the team achieves clarity of thought around what to build."

WORKING BACKWARDS · BRYAR & CARR

2 THE DIAGNOSTIC LINE FOUNDERS SKIP

Inside the Working Backwards canon there is a single sentence that should be stenciled on the wall of every founder's office. It is the line that distinguishes a real PR/FAQ from theater:

"You started with what your company can do and worked backward from there. This press release should be discarded."

WORKING BACKWARDS

Read that twice. The verdict isn't *revise* — it's *discard*. The PR/FAQ is a forcing function for honesty about whose problem you're actually solving.

Brian Welsh, writing on reverse planning as a leadership discipline, points to research from Iowa, Peking, and Korea on the same effect. The researchers call the technique *future introspection*: imagining the goal as already achieved, then walking the steps backward. Amazon arrived at the discipline by accident; the academy arrived at it by experiment.

If the press release is hard to write, the product is going to suck.

Ian McAllister's rule of thumb is the most useful single test I've encountered for AI founder strategy. It scales from a side project to a Series B.

"If the press release is hard to write, then the product is probably going to suck."

IAN MCALLISTER

The reason is structural, not literary. A press release has a fixed shape: headline, sub-headline, customer quote, founder quote, call to action. To write it cleanly, you must know — in plain language — **who the customer is, what specific problem you solve for them, why now, and what the alternative is.** If you can't make those four things land in a paragraph a journalist would actually publish, the product hasn't been thought through.

WHY THIS HITS HARDER FOR AI COMPANIES

Because AI is a horizontal capability, the temptation to lead with the technology is overwhelming. A press release written from the model — "powered by GPT-4o," "agentic workflow orchestration," "trained on proprietary data" — is forward-from-tech writing. A press release written from the customer is the opposite: it names a person, a job, a Tuesday-morning frustration, and the moment that frustration ends.

FORWARD PLANNING

"Our agentic workflow platform leverages..."

Headline foregrounds capability. Reads like the team's identity. Customer is implicit, generic — a placeholder.

REVERSE PLANNING

"Claims adjusters now close 40% of cases without leaving Slack."

Headline foregrounds outcome. Customer is named. The technology is a means, not the message.

If the second version is harder to write, that's the diagnostic. Don't fix the press release. Fix the company.

03 Three voices. Same warning.

The pattern is so consistent that the most influential operators in the AI ecosystem are saying it in different rooms, in different words, to different audiences — and almost no one in the founder seat is hearing it.

ERIC RIES · ON THE FAILURE MODE

"It was working forward from the technology instead of working backward from the business results you're trying to achieve."

ERIC RIES · SUMMARIZING THE MOST COMMON LEAN STARTUP MISS

Ries was not talking about AI specifically — he was describing the universal trap. AI just makes the trap more attractive, because the technology is genuinely impressive on its own. The story it lets you tell about itself is more convincing than the story your customer would tell about themselves.

SAM ALTMAN · TO FOUNDERS, AT YC AI STARTUP SCHOOL

"Do something different. Something we can't do."

SAM ALTMAN · TO FOUNDERS PITCHING CHATGPT CLONES

Translated: don't plan forward from the model that already exists. If your roadmap is a slightly-better version of what's already shipped by a frontier lab, you've planned forward from OpenAI's roadmap, not your customer's workflow.

SEQUOIA · AT AI ASCENT 2025

"Solve the customer's entire problem. Don't just throw tools at them."

SEQUOIA · AI ASCENT 2025

The investor framing is identical to the operator framing. Workflow-backward beats model-forward. Tooling is what you ship; outcome is what they buy.

04 \$33M. 1.3M users. No PMF.

Yupp.ai's 2025 shutdown is the cleanest recent illustration of forward planning at scale. The numbers were excellent. The premise was not.

CASE STUDY · 2025

Yupp.ai — a model-comparison platform that ran out of reason to exist.

Yupp.ai launched as a place where users could compare outputs from different AI models side-by-side and rank them. The thesis was forward-from-technology: models exist, they differ, therefore a comparison product has value.

The capital agreed. Andreessen Horowitz, with Chris Dixon leading, put in a \$33M seed. The traction agreed too — the platform reached 1.3 million users. By every superficial metric the company looked like a winner.

And then it shut down. The founders' own post-mortem cited the failure to find "strong enough product-market fit" — the polite operator phrase for: *nobody actually needed this on a Tuesday morning*. Comparison was a behavior the founders thought users wanted because the founders themselves wanted it. The customer never showed up.

\$33M 1.3M 0

SEED ROUND, LED BY A16Z

REGISTERED USERS AT PEAK

CUSTOMERS WHO COULDN'T
LIVE WITHOUT IT

The mistake at Yupp.ai was not execution. The team shipped. The mistake was the original PR/FAQ that was never written. Had it been, the customer quote would have read something like: *"I love being able to compare models."* Which, said out loud, sounds exactly like what it is — a hobby, not a job.

05

Five questions before your next roadmap review.

If you cannot answer these in plain language — without using the words *agent*, *model*, *platform*, or *AI* — you are forward planning.

Q · 01 Who is the customer, by name and role, and what was their Tuesday morning like before our product existed?

If the answer is a market segment instead of a person, you don't have a customer — you have a TAM slide.

Q · 02 What specific outcome are they hiring us for — measured in their currency, not ours?

"Faster" is our currency. "Closes the quarter without three sleepless nights" is theirs.

Q · 03 What is the alternative they're using right now — including doing nothing — and why would they switch?

If the honest answer is "they wouldn't," you're not selling a product. You're hoping for one.

Q · 04 If a frontier lab shipped a free feature tomorrow that did 80% of what we do, would we still have a business?

If no, you've planned forward from a model that doesn't belong to you. Plan backward from the workflow that does.

Q · 05 If we wrote the launch-day press release right now, would a journalist actually publish it — or would it read like a feature list?

McAllister's test, restated. If the writing is hard, the product is hard. Fix the company, not the copy.

Plan from the customer. Or plan from the model.

The companies that survive the next eighteen months will not be the ones with the best models. They will be the ones whose roadmaps survive contact with a customer who has never heard the word agentic. Reverse planning is not a methodology. It is a discipline of attention – and like any discipline, it has to be practiced before it's needed.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Sage Faraday is a Fractional CTO and partner at Rosenblatt AI. She works with early-stage AI founders on the gap between what their model can do and what their customers will actually pay for.